

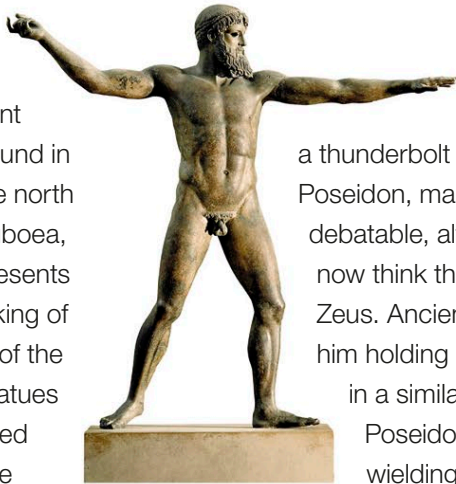


Artemision Bronze

△ **Head of the statue** showing finely rendered hair

The Artemision Bronze is an ancient Greek sculpture found in a shipwreck off the north coast of the Greek island Euboea, in the Mediterranean. It represents either the Greek god Zeus, king of the gods, or Poseidon, god of the sea. Most ancient bronze statues have since been lost or melted down, making this one all the more precious.

Dating from 460–c.450 BCE, the nude bronze figure stands at 2.09m (6ft 10in). It shows the realistic anatomy of the Greek Classical period, though the arms are disproportionately long, exaggerating the dramatic pose. The wide stance and extended arms – one poised to hurl a weapon and the other taking aim – suggest great power about to be unleashed. An



Front view of the bronze statue

object missing from the right hand, either a thunderbolt for Zeus or a trident for Poseidon, makes the god's identity debatable, although most scholars now think the sculpture represents Zeus. Ancient Greek pottery shows him holding his thunderbolt aloft in a similar stance, whereas Poseidon is normally depicted wielding his trident downwards.

The shipwreck that contained the statue was

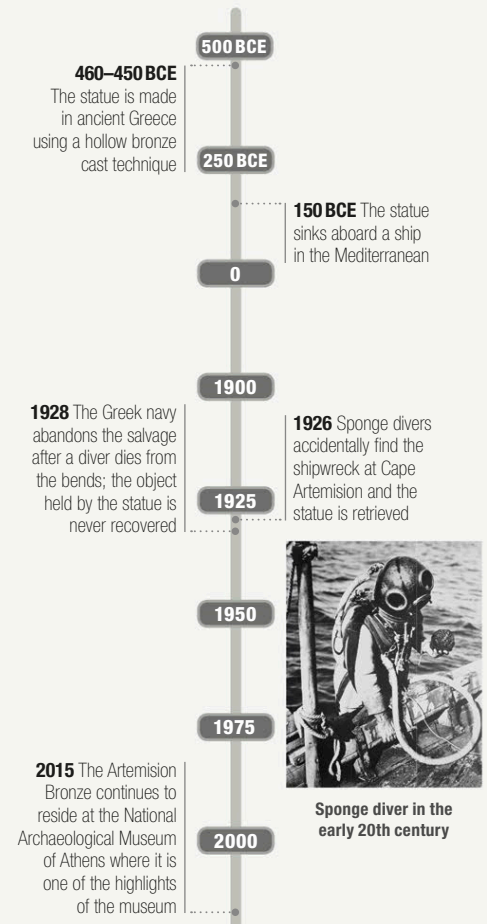
first discovered by sponge divers in 1926, and a subsequent salvage operation by the Greek navy recovered the Artemision Bronze in two pieces, along with various other treasures. However, the exploration was called off in 1928 after a diver died, and it was never resumed, despite the wreck lying only 40m (130ft) below the surface. It is thought that the ship may have been of Roman origin, bringing back looted treasures from Greece to Italy. Ironically, the statue was saved and preserved for future generations after it ended up on the bottom of the sea.



Pottery figure of the Greek god Zeus, thought to be from around 500 BCE, depicted holding a spear or javelin in place of his customary thunderbolt

Key dates

460 BCE–2015



The bearded god once hurled a weapon held in his right hand, probably a thunderbolt, in which case he is Zeus

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